THE EARLY YEARS TOOLKIT

Early Years Curriculum Planning

Date	
Age/Group/Room	0-2 years
Topic	All about me
Activity	Sensory Basket – Exploring familiar everyday items

Materials Required

- Large, shallow basket (easy for babies and toddlers to access and explore)

Filled with:

Familiar everyday items:

- Soft hairbrush
- Toothbrush
- Flannel
- Empty bottle
- Nappy
- Spoon, cup, and bowl

Natural materials (for sensory exploration):

- Sponge
- Pine cones (ensure smooth and safe)
- Large pebble
- Seashell

Textiles (varied textures):

- Soft teddy or plush fabric
- Silk or satin scarf
- Woollen glove

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Adaptations for Inclusion

I will provide larger, easy-to-hold items for younger children or those developing fine motor skills
I will use high-contrast or brightly coloured materials where needed
I will include familiar items or comfort objects from home to support children who may need reassurance
I will sit alongside children to model play and support engagement
I will limit the number of items to avoid overstimulation
I will allow children to explore freely at their own pace
I will use simple language and repetition to support understanding
I will offer a variety of textures to support different sensory preferences
I will ensure all items are safe and appropriate for mouthing

Learning Objectives

- [ ] Community
- [x] Wellbeing
- [x] Learning

- [x] Communication

- [x] Identity

I will support children to begin recognising familiar objects and developing a sense of self
I will encourage children to explore everyday items using their senses
I will support children to build confidence through independent exploration
I will model and use simple language to support early communication
I will respond to children's cues to build secure, trusting relationships
I will support children to explore, investigate, and make sense of the materials through sensory play

Development Areas

- [x] Social and Emotional

- [x] Physical

- [x] Cognitive

- [x] Language and Communication

- [ ] Creative and Expressive

Social and Emotional:
I will support children to develop a sense of security and confidence as they explore familiar objects, building connections through shared interaction.
Physical:
I will encourage children to reach, grasp, hold, and manipulate objects, supporting the development of fine and gross motor skills.
Cognitive:
I will support children to explore and investigate materials, developing curiosity and an understanding of cause and effect.
Language and Communication:
I will model simple language, name objects, and respond to children's sounds and gestures to support early communication.

EYLF intentional Link/Rationale

Outcome 1: Children have a strong sense of identity
I will support children to develop a sense of self by providing familiar objects and opportunities to explore items connected to their daily lives.
Outcome 3: Children have a strong sense of wellbeing
I will create a calm and secure environment where children feel safe to explore, supporting their confidence and emotional wellbeing.
Outcome 5: Children are effective communicators
I will model simple language, name objects, and respond to children's sounds and gestures to support early communication and interaction.
Rationale:
I have planned this experience to support children in developing a sense of identity through exploration of familiar objects and everyday items. By engaging in sensory play and responsive interactions, children are able to build confidence, develop early communication skills, and form secure relationships.

Key Vocabulary / Educators Role

THE EARLY YEARS TOOLKIT

I will sit alongside children and support their exploration of the basket
I will model simple language by naming objects and describing textures
I will respond to children's sounds, gestures, and cues
I will encourage children to explore familiar items at their own pace
I will create a calm and supportive environment
I will follow each child's interests and extend their play where appropriate

Reflection

Did the child engage with the items in the basket?

Did they show curiosity or interest in particular objects?

How did they respond to my interaction and support?

Were they reaching, grasping, exploring, or vocalising?

Did they show a preference for certain items or textures?

Did they need support or reassurance during the experience?

Next Steps

I will introduce photos of the child and their family to strengthen connections to identity and belonging
I will begin naming body parts during play to extend children's understanding of themselves
I will add simple emotion faces (happy/sad) to support early emotional awareness
I will repeat the experience regularly to build familiarity and confidence
I will observe children's interests and introduce new items to extend their exploration
I will encourage children to begin pointing, selecting, or indicating preferences